

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 212

By Todd

A RESOLUTION to commemorate the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Sportfish Restoration Program as part of the American System of Conservation Funding.

WHEREAS, more than a century ago, hunters and anglers were among the first conservationists who realized America's natural resources were in peril and could not sustain unregulated harvest and habitat destruction; and

WHEREAS, sportsmen and sportswomen took it upon themselves to support laws that stopped excessive harvest of fish and wildlife, established state agencies to protect fish, wildlife, and their habitats, and supported special fishing and hunting license fees to help fund the new agencies' efforts to provide healthy natural resources for future generations; and

WHEREAS, the Tennessee General Assembly, then and now, has recognized that the primary authority to protect and manage fish within our State waters resides in our state agencies; and

WHEREAS, upon realizing that license fees alone were insufficient to restore and sustain healthy fish populations, anglers supported excise taxes on fishing equipment to raise additional funds to support restoration and enhancement efforts of the state agencies across the nation; and

WHEREAS, the Sport Fish Restoration Program, which began seventy-five years ago with the passage of the Federal Aid in Sport Fish Restoration Act in 1950 (further expanded with the Wallop-Breaux amendment to the Sport Fish Restoration Act in 1984), is a vital part of conservation funding in the United States; and

WHEREAS, a manufacturers excise tax on fishing equipment, along with an excise tax on motorboat and small engine fuels, is mostly distributed back to the states through the U. S.

Fish and Wildlife Service for fisheries conservation, management, and angler and boater access; and

WHEREAS, this cooperative partnership between the sportfishing industry, anglers, boaters, the U. S. Fish and Wildlife Service, and state natural resource agencies has resulted in the most successful model of fisheries management in the world, restoring and enhancing populations across the United States and its territories; and

WHEREAS, since 1939, the combined contributions of the Wildlife and Sport Fish Restoration Programs and license fees to state fish and wildlife agencies exceed 78 billion dollars (more than any other single conservation effort in American history), which constitute, collectively, the American System of Conservation Funding; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we commemorate the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Sport Fish Restoration Program as part of the American System of Conservation Funding, applauding America's anglers and boaters, the sportfishing industry, state fish and wildlife agencies, and the U. S. Fish and Wildlife Service for their leading role in restoring healthy populations of fish and aquatic resources, both game and non-game, to the abundance we see today.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that a certified copy of this resolution be provided to the Tennessee Wildlife Resources Agency, each member of the Tennessee congressional delegation, and the U. S. Fish and Wildlife Service.